# Website Internationalization (i18n) Implementation Report

meridianexport.com — Spanish (LATAM) & Russian (Kazakhstan/CIS)

**Meridian Freight Inc.**
Date: March 24, 2026
Status:
DEPLOYED & LIVE

## Executive Summary

The Meridian Freight corporate website (meridianexport.com) has been expanded from English-only to a fully trilingual platform supporting **English**, **Spanish** (LATAM neutral), and **Russian** (targeting Kazakhstan and CIS markets). The implementation is live in production with all 125 pages serving localized content, market-tailored messaging, and full analytics coverage.

| 3 | 125 | 271 | 0 |
|---|---|---|---|
| Languages | Pages Deployed | Translation Keys | Build Errors |

## Live URLs

```
English (default): https://meridianexport.com
Spanish (LATAM): https://meridianexport.com/es
Russian (KZ/CIS): https://meridianexport.com/ru
```

English URLs are **unchanged** — no `/en/` prefix, preserving all existing SEO equity and backlinks.

## Business Rationale

| Market | Opportunity | Language |
|---|---|---|
| Latin America | $9.99B construction equipment market (2025), 4.3% YoY growth. Key: Mexico, Chile, Colombia, Peru, Argentina | Neutral LATAM Spanish |
| Kazakhstan & CIS | $2.5B JD strategic investment in Kazakhstan. Russian also covers Uzbekistan (34.6% machinery imports) and Kyrgyzstan | Standard business Russian |
| Yandex SEO | 23.2% search market share in Kazakhstan (growing). Russian content enables Yandex indexing | Russian |

## What Was Implemented

### 1. Internationalization Infrastructure

| Component | Technology | Details |
|---|---|---|
| i18n Library | next-intl | 457 bytes client bundle, native Next.js 16 App Router integration |
| URL Strategy | Subdirectory routing | `/es/` and `/ru/` prefixes; English at root |
| Locale Detection | Proxy middleware | Cookie > Accept-Language header > default (English) |
| Static Generation | SSG (all pages) | 125 pages pre-rendered at build time, zero runtime cost |
| Font Support | Geist Sans/Mono | Added Cyrillic + Latin Extended subsets for Russian and Spanish |

### 2. Content Translation (271 UI Keys + 5 Content Files)

| Content Type | Scope | Approach |
|---|---|---|
| UI strings (buttons, labels, nav) | 271 keys x 3 languages | JSON translation files |
| Services (6 pages) | Title, description, FAQs per locale | AI-translated, locale-indexed TypeScript |
| Equipment types (8 pages) | All text fields translated | AI-translated, brand names preserved |
| Destinations (8 pages) | Market-tailored ordering per locale | AI-translated + reordered by market |
| FAQ (20+ entries) | All Q&A + locale-specific additions | AI-translated + 3 market-specific FAQs per locale |
| Projects (6 entries) | Titles, descriptions, market ordering | AI-translated + market-prioritized |
| Page metadata (all pages) | Titles, descriptions, OG tags | Dynamic generateMetadata per locale |

### 3. Market-Tailored Content

| Element | Spanish (LATAM) | Russian (KZ/CIS) |
|---|---|---|
| Destination ordering | Mexico, Colombia, Brazil first | Kazakhstan first, then Turkey, UAE |
| Project showcase | LATAM-destination projects prioritized | CIS-destination projects prioritized |
| FAQ additions | LATAM customs, shipping times, WhatsApp | KZ GOST standards, EAEU duty exemptions, CIS routes |
| Trust signals | "500+ exports to Latin America" | "Exports to Kazakhstan & Central Asia" |

### 4. Language Switcher

Globe icon + locale dropdown (EN / ES / RU) added to both header navigation (desktop and mobile) and footer. Clicking switches to the same page in the selected language. Cookie remembers user preference across sessions.

### 5. SEO Implementation

| SEO Element | Status | Details |
|---|---|---|
| hreflang tags | Live | en, es, ru-KZ, x-default on every page (HTTP headers) |
| Sitemap alternates | Live | Every URL includes xhtml:link alternates for all 3 locales |
| Canonical URLs | Live | Locale-aware canonical per page |
| OG tags localized | Live | Title and description in page language |
| JSON-LD schemas | Live | Localized business descriptions |
| English URL preservation | Live | No /en/ prefix — zero disruption to existing rankings |

### 6. Analytics & Tracking (GA4 + Meta Pixel)

| Feature | Status | Details |
|---|---|---|
| GA4 locale dimension | Live | `locale` custom dimension on every gtag config |
| Content grouping | Live | Strips /es/ and /ru/ prefixes for consistent grouping |
| Region-aware consent | Live | analytics_storage granted globally, denied for 31 EEA/UK/CH countries |
| Meta Pixel | Live | PageView fires on all locales, consent mode unchanged |
| Meta CAPI | Live | Server-side Lead events fire on all locales |
| Contact event tracking | Live | WhatsApp, phone, email clicks include locale param |

### 7. Email & Notifications

| Feature | Status | Details |
|---|---|---|
| Contact form auto-reply | Live | Sent in visitor's language (EN/ES/RU) |
| Calculator estimate email | Live | Subject + intro + footer in visitor's language |
| Admin notification email | Live | Subject tagged [ES] or [RU] for non-English leads |
| Slack notifications | Live | Tagged with locale for team awareness |

## GA4 Consent Fix (Critical)

During the analytics audit, we discovered that **GA4 was recording zero traffic** since implementation. The root cause: Consent Mode v2 defaulted `analytics_storage` to `denied` globally, meaning visitors who didn't click "Accept" on the cookie banner were invisible to GA4 reports.

**Fix deployed:** Region-aware consent defaults. Analytics tracking is now `granted` by default for all non-EU visitors (LATAM, Kazakhstan, USA, etc.). EU/EEA/UK visitors (31 countries) still require cookie consent per GDPR. Ad tracking remains consent-gated everywhere. Google auto-detects visitor region — no custom geo-detection needed.

## Technical Summary

| Metric | Value |
|---|---|
| Files changed | 64 files (+5,590 lines) |
| New files created | 12 (i18n config, proxy, messages, language switcher) |
| Components updated | 17 with useTranslations() |
| Pages moved to [locale]/ | 15 pages + error/loading boundaries |
| Content files localized | 5 (services, equipment, destinations, FAQ, projects) |
| Total static pages | 125 (across 3 locales) |
| Build time | ~2.2s compile + 0.5s page generation |
| Deploy time | ~45s on Vercel |
| Unit tests | 70/70 passing |
| Build errors | 0 |

## Deferred / Next Steps

| Item | Status | Action Required |
|---|---|---|
| Blog translation | Deferred | Infrastructure ready. Add ES/RU content to content/blog.ts when translations are available |
| Yandex Webmaster | Pending | Register site at webmaster.yandex.com and submit sitemap for Kazakhstan indexing |
| Human translation review | Recommended | Have native Spanish and Russian speakers review AI-generated translations before major campaigns |
| Portuguese (Brazil) | Future | Brazil = 24.4% of LATAM equipment market. Add when justified by traffic/demand |